
1.3 Social psychology — obedience and prejudice

Students will be assessed on their ability to:

- 1 Definition of the approach**
 - a Define social psychology showing understanding that the approach is about aspects of human behaviour that involve the individual's relationships to other persons, groups and society, including cultural influences on behaviour.
 - b Define and use psychological terminology accurately and appropriately including the terms:
 - i agentic state
 - ii autonomous state
 - iii moral strain
 - iv in-group/out-group
 - v social categorisation
 - vi social identification
 - vii social comparison.

2 Methodology/ How Science Works

- a Describe the survey as a research method in psychology, including the questionnaire and interview.
- b Identify, describe and apply unstructured, structured and semi-structured interviews, open and closed questions, alternative hypotheses and issues around designing surveys.
- c Describe and compare, including strengths and weaknesses, the difference between qualitative and quantitative data.
- d Evaluate the survey as a research method, including strengths and weaknesses, and the issues of reliability, validity and subjectivity.
- e Describe, assess and apply guidelines, such as British Psychological Society (BPS) guidelines, about the use of humans in psychological research including guidelines about what not to do, and what to do to protect human participants. Guidelines to include consent, deception, right to withdraw, debriefing of participants and competence.
- f Identify, describe and apply different sampling techniques including random sampling, stratified sampling, volunteer and self-selected sampling, and opportunity sampling, including advantages and disadvantages of each technique.

3 Content

- a Define what is meant by obedience.
- b Describe and evaluate Milgram's (1963) study of obedience and one of Milgram's 'variation' studies.
- c Describe and evaluate the Agency Theory of Obedience (Milgram, 1973).
- d Describe and assess the ethical issues arising from obedience research (as applied to the participants in the study and the wider issues for society).
- e Describe and evaluate one study of obedience from a country other than Milgram's (USA).

Suitable example:

- Meeus and Raaijmakers (1986) Administrative obedience. Carrying out orders to use psychological-administrative violence.
- f Compare Milgram's (1963) obedience study and one other from a country other than Milgram's (USA) drawing cross-cultural conclusions.
- g Describe what is meant by prejudice and discrimination.
- h Describe and evaluate Tajfel's (1970) Social Identity Theory as an explanation of prejudice.

4 Studies in detail

- a Describe and evaluate **two** studies in detail. One of the studies must be Hofling et al (1966) Study of obedience in nurses and **one other** study of either obedience or prejudice in the Social Approach. This **must** be selected from the following:
 - Sherif (1961/1988) 'Robbers' Cave' experiment
 - Tajfel et al (1970) study of minimal groups
 - Reicher and Haslam (2006) Rethinking the psychology of tyranny: The BBC prison study.

5 Key issue

- a Describe one key issue of relevance to today's society and apply concepts, theories and/or research (as appropriate) drawn from the Social Approach to explain the issue.

Suitable examples:

- blind obedience to authority in a prison setting (for example the Abu Ghraib situation)
- obedience during conflict resulting in harm to others (for example Mi Lai Massacre, Vietnam 1968)
- football violence
- race riots (for example St Paul's, Bristol 1980)
- cult behaviour.

Note: in examination, students may be given stimulus material from a key issue to explain using concepts, theories and/or research (as appropriate) from the Social Approach.

6 Evidence of practice: short survey

- a Devise and conduct **one** practical to gather data relevant to topics covered in the Social Approach, which must be a survey (questionnaire or interview) to gather relevant data. The survey should gather both qualitative and quantitative data. This practical must be designed and conducted according to ethical principles.

Suitable examples:

- gender differences in obedience
- prejudicial attitudes towards age
- in group/out group attitudes.

- b Make design decisions in devising an interview schedule/questionnaire including sampling decisions.
- c Collect data and present an analysis of both the qualitative and quantitative data and draw brief conclusions about the topic from the analyses.